



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Self-Harm and Suicidal Thoughts: A Guide for Parents

Recognising the signs, asking directly, staying calm, making home safer, and working with the school.

Before You Read

This guide covers self-harm and suicidal thoughts in children and young people.

This guide is about self-harm and suicidal thoughts: recognising the signs, talking with your child, keeping them safe, and working with the school. It does not describe methods, but some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience.

- If you are worried your child is in immediate danger, call 999 or take them to A&E.
- For urgent mental health help that isn't an emergency, call **NHS 111** and choose the mental health option (option 2), any time.
- **Samaritans**: 116 123, free, any time, including for parents.

About This Guide

Finding out that your child is hurting themselves, or has thought about ending their life, is frightening. This guide helps you **recognise the signs, ask directly, respond calmly, make home safer, work with the school, and look after yourself.**

- Self-harm is usually a way of coping with overwhelming feelings. It is not attention-seeking.
- Self-harm and suicidal thoughts are different, but they can go together, so it is important to ask about both.
- Suicide is preventable. Your calm, your listening and your help in getting support make a real difference.

Key Words

Self-harm

When a young person hurts themselves on purpose, usually to cope with difficult feelings.

Suicidal thoughts

Thoughts about not wanting to be alive, or about ending their life. They can come and go.

Safety plan

A written plan made with your child, and often with professionals: warning signs, what helps, and who to contact in a crisis.

CAMHS

NHS children and young people's mental health services (also called CYPMHS). The GP or school can usually refer.

What the Evidence Shows

24.1%

of 17-year-olds in the UK had self-harmed in the previous year

Patalay and Fitzsimons, 2021

1 in 5

8 to 16 year olds in England had a probable mental disorder in 2023

NHS England, 2023

About half

of young people under 25 who died by suicide had previously self-harmed

NCISH, 2017

Millennium Cohort Study survey of 10,103 young people at age 17 (2018 to 2019); NHS survey February to April 2023. Checked September 2026. Self-harm is common, and it always deserves a caring response and support.

Signs to Look For

Age

What you might notice

8 to 11 Big changes in mood or behaviour, clinginess or withdrawal, trouble sleeping, saying they are "bad" or wish they weren't here, unexplained injuries.

Age	What you might notice
11 to 14	Withdrawing from family and friends, covering arms or legs in warm weather, avoiding PE or swimming, spending long periods alone, changes in eating or sleep.
14 to 18	Hopelessness, talking about being a burden or not being around, giving things away, more risk-taking, pressure around exams or relationships, searching or posting about self-harm or suicide.

Some of these are part of growing up. What matters is change, how long it lasts, and your instinct. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again** before asking your child, or contacting the school or your GP.

Asking Directly

- **Ask the question, in clear words.** "Are you having thoughts of suicide?" "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Talking about suicidal thoughts will not increase the risk or put ideas in their head (YoungMinds).
- **Ask about self-harm gently.** "Sometimes when people feel really bad, they hurt themselves to cope. Has that been happening for you?"
- **Choose a calm moment:** side by side in the car, on a walk, or while doing something together can feel easier than face to face.
- **Listen more than you speak.** Avoid "why" questions, which can sound like blame. Try "Tell me what's been happening."
- **Thank them for telling you.** "I'm really glad you told me. We'll get through this together."

Staying Calm

What Helps

- A calm voice and body language, even if you feel panicked inside
- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- Keeping the focus on feelings, not the injuries
- Letting them know you love them, and that you'll help them get support

What Can Make It Harder

- Anger, shouting or punishment, including taking their phone away for telling you
- Making them promise to stop straight away
- "How could you do this to us?" or other words that add guilt
- Asking to see injuries, or checking their body without their agreement

Try not to respond with panic: it can stop your child being honest with you. It is fine to say, "I need a moment, but I'm not angry with you."

If Your Child Has Hurt Themselves, or Is Thinking About Suicide

What to Do

- **Call 999** if your child is seriously injured, has taken an overdose or swallowed something harmful (even if they seem well), or if you feel they can't keep themselves safe. If they are in danger, call 999 or take them to A&E.
- **For minor injuries**, give first aid and see your GP or a pharmacist if needed. YoungMinds advises taking your child to hospital or the GP for any injury that needs medical attention.
- **If they have suicidal thoughts but are not in immediate danger**, stay with them, and call NHS 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2) for urgent advice, any time.
- **Book a GP appointment** to talk about support and a referral to mental health services.
- **Tell the school's safeguarding team**, so your child can be supported during the day.

Making Home Safer

- Keep **medicines**, including everyday ones, and **sharp items** safely stored or locked away, and reduce access to anything else that could be used to cause harm (Evelina London, NHS).
- Ask your child what would help them feel safer at home, and agree changes together where you can (YoungMinds).
- Make a safety plan together, ideally with help from professionals: warning signs, what helps, and who to call. Stay Alive app (Grassroots Suicide Prevention): free, with a personal safety plan and a directory of help.

- Agree a signal or code word your child can use to let you know things are getting harder.
- Keep the numbers in this guide somewhere easy to find, for them and for you.
- Stay connected: time together, regular meals and gentle routines matter more than big conversations.

If Your Child Is Worried About a Friend

- Thank your child for telling you. Make it clear it is **not their job to keep their friend safe**, and they were right to speak up.
- If the friend may be in immediate danger, call 999.
- Otherwise, contact the school's safeguarding team straight away, or the friend's school if it is different. The school will decide how to approach the friend and their family.
- Don't contact the other child or their family directly before speaking to the school; the school can make sure it is done safely.
- Check in on your own child: worrying about a friend can be frightening and exhausting.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the signs, including injuries, withdrawal and what students say or write
● Engage	Listen calmly, privately and without judgement, and ask directly about suicide
● Support	Make sure your child is safe; first aid and medical help where needed; never left alone if at risk
● Pause	Think before acting; never investigate, shame or promise secrecy
● Offer	Model alternatives and explain what happens next

Step	What staff do
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team straight away where there is risk, and always the same day
● Document	Record what happened, factually

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- Where there is a risk to your child's safety, you will usually be contacted the same day. The school may also seek urgent advice from NHS mental health services.
- The school can put support in place during the day, such as a key adult, a safe space, adjustments to PE or exams, and a plan for returning after time off.

Looking After Yourself

- Supporting a child who is self-harming or feeling suicidal is incredibly hard. Shock, fear, guilt, anger and grief are all normal reactions.
- It is not your fault, and you don't have to do this alone. Talk to someone you trust, your GP, or a helpline.
- Look after your own sleep, food and breaks, and share the load with other trusted adults where you can.
- Brothers and sisters may be affected too. Keep an eye on them, and let them talk.
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free from any phone, any time, day or night, whatever your age

- **CALM (for adults, 18 and over):** 0800 58 58 58, 5pm to midnight every day, or webchat at thecalmzone.net

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Asking about suicide will put the idea in their head"	It won't. Asking clearly can help your child feel able to talk.
"Self-harm is attention-seeking"	It is usually a hidden way of coping with painful feelings, and a sign your child needs support.
"If I punish it, it will stop"	Punishment usually adds shame and secrecy. Calm support and professional help work better.
"They said they didn't mean it, so it's fine"	Take every mention of wanting to die seriously, and get advice.
"It's just a phase"	Some changes are part of growing up, but self-harm and suicidal thoughts always deserve support.

Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **NHS 111:** call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free from any phone, any time, day or night, whatever your age
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7 (for you or your child)
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or childline.org.uk
- **Your GP**, for support and a referral to mental health services
- **Emergency:** call 999 or go to A&E

Further reading

- YoungMinds, *Suicidal thoughts: a guide for parents*
- YoungMinds, *Self-harm: a guide for parents*
- Evelina London Children's Hospital (Guy's and St Thomas' NHS Foundation Trust), *Staying safe: information for parents*
- NHS, *Where to get urgent help for mental health*
- YoungMinds, *Guide to CAMHS*

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Self-Harm and Suicidal Thoughts: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 34 - Ages 8 to 18

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